

Mustali Kachwala

It wasn't until too long ago that Linux for your desktop was inconceivable, not because it wasn't present (there were hundreds of options available even then), but because Linux meant geek. Perceptions ranged from, "It's not for me" to, "I am not a NASA space scientist." Well, here's the good news: it's not true anymore. Individuals and small businesses are moving over to Linux—even if it is only a small trickle—and finding it as simple as Microsoft Windows.

Linux also has some other inherent advantages—it is more

ness. You'll also find a section on LIVE CD distributions, which are Linux distributions that can be run straight off the CD drive, without altering your existing set up.

Linux is best when it comes to security. It is more or less immune to virus threats.

It has a bunch of GUI tools to configure various devices such as modem, network cards, and dial-up connection. Similarly, it has simple GUI tools for CD burning, CD ripping, and audio file conversion. Common office chores such as dragging a file to or from the network are really easy. Linux shows the hidden shares, the shares suffixed with a dollar '\$' sign at the end. Flash-enabled

It is stable, costs little, and has, literally, hundreds of free software options

the OS. The audio and video chat clients are disappointing, as there is an inconsistency in the applications that are bundled along with the various distributions. However, text messaging remains consistent with Gaim and Kopete.

Getting used to the Linux environment will be a bigger challenge than the applications. Every now and then you'll want to switch back to Windows. New adopters in offices should opt for a dual boot system, so that they can tackle critical situations.

Users will find it difficult to use software which appears radically different such as GIMP, compared to Paint. For example, in Paint, pressing the 'Print screen' button



Flavours Available

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stable (although Microsoft Windows XP is as stable), costs less, and has, literally, hundreds of free software options. Most importantly, piracy issues are something you'd never have to deal with again—both as an individual, or as a small business.

It is therefore pertinent to ask: If you are moving over to Linux, or thinking of setting up your systems based on Open Source, which Linux is right for you?

Given the options available, it is not a simple task. Also, it will be some time until Linux overcomes some issues such as hardware compatibility, interoperability with other OSes, and weaning users away from the Windows GUI.

Digit looked at the various options available in the market, and found out which is the most appropriate one for your busi-

ness. You'll also find a section on LIVE CD distributions, which are Linux distributions that can be run straight off the CD drive, without altering your existing set up.

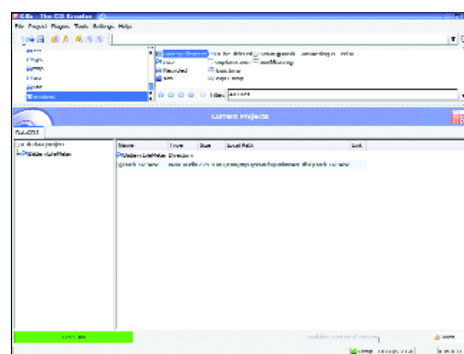
Linux will disappoint you when it comes to dealing with multimedia applications. It plays VCDs, but doesn't play DVDs. There are lots of legal issues, too, that need to be tackled. Playing MP3s is simple, but you can't play other formats such as OGG without using a plug-in. The plug-in you have at your disposal depends upon the choice of

Internet browsers, better than IE, come with the Linux OS, with lots of plug-ins—mouse gestures, etc.

For a typical Windows user, a personal finance manager wouldn't be common. Even if you get one, it won't be bundled with the OS. But Linux comes with Gnu-cash, a free personal finance manager. You just need to run the application and start using it.

Nero in Windows allows a multi-session CD to be burnt with disc-at-once option, which it shouldn't. This CD doesn't work in Linux. Also in Linux, the unclosed multi-session CD can't be read without the help of a CD writer.

Some people have a craze for Windows applications, and they want to use the same in Linux too, which is actually possible. You just need to install an emulator software such as Wine, Crossover Office or VMware, and get started. But if you use any proprietary application



This GUI tool makes it easy to burn CDs and DVDs in Linux